Bolshevik Revolution. But to gain a deeper understanding, we should also view them as revolutions in the way information flows. Christianity was obviously different from Greek polytheism in many of its myths and rites, yet it was also different in the importance it gave to a single holy book and the institution entrusted with interpreting it. Consequently, whereas each temple of Zeus was a separate entity, each Christian church became a node in a unified network.[4] Information flowed differently among the followers of Christ than among the worshippers of Zeus. Similarly, Stalin's USSR was a different kind of information network from Peter the Great's empire. Stalin enacted many unprecedented economic policies, but what enabled him to do it is that he headed a totalitarian network in which the centre accumulated enough information to micromanage the lives of hundreds of millions of people. Technology is rarely deterministic, and the same technology can be used in very different ways. But without the invention of technologies like the book and the telegraph, the Christian Church and the Stalinist apparatus would never have been possible.

This historical lesson should strongly encourage us to pay more attention to the AI revolution in our current political debates. The invention of AI is potentially more momentous than the invention of the telegraph, the printing press or even writing because AI is the first technology that is capable of making decisions and generating ideas by itself. Whereas printing presses and parchment scrolls offered new means for connecting people, AIs are full-fledged members in our information networks, possessing their own agency. In coming years, all networks – from armies to religions – will gain millions of new AI members, which will process data differently than humans do. These new members will make alien decisions and generate alien ideas – that is, decisions and ideas that are unlikely to occur to humans. The addition of many alien agents is bound to change the shape of armies, religions, markets and nations. Entire political, economic and social systems might collapse, and new ones will take their place. That's why AI should be an urgent matter even to people who don't care about technology and who think the most important political questions concern the survival of democracy or the fair distribution of wealth.

This book has juxtaposed the discussion of AI with the discussion of sacred canons like the Bible, because we are now at the critical moment of AI canonisation. When church fathers like Bishop Athanasius decided to include 1 Timothy in the biblical dataset while excluding the Acts of Paul